who had not heard the challenge, nor seen the ADP since he had his back towards them. While the others had jumped out, he had innocently stayed in the boat and got shot. A most tragic and unfortunate incident. No terrorist angle there. An act carried out in good faith by the ADP in the discharge of their duties, with no malicious intent or premeditation. The village folk were called together and the SHO explained the chain of events. The villagers were understandably agitated but also knew that their boys were at fault and guilty of poaching. Reports were submitted up the Army chain of command and included in the daily sitrep. We did not try to hide the facts or to show it as an 'encounter', in order to avoid any censure for having caused the death of an innocent civilian. An FIR was filed, investigated and disposed of as per the law of the land. No one was punished or censured for doing his duty. More importantly, the Army chain of command understood the ambiguous nature of the rules of engagement and that there was no premeditation or mala fide intent.

On another occasion, the fallout was even worse. We were carrying out a cordon and search operation at Trigam, another 'black' village in the Alpha Company's AOR. It was a big village, divided into a number of mohallas, sub-divisions, each having more than a hundred houses. It was a Battalion-sized operation; four Companies in the cordon and three to four search parties per Company. As per the practice, the villagers were asked to vacate their houses and assemble in designated areas in each of the mohallas. A head count was taken and all missing persons were accounted for—those who had gone out for work or studies, etc. Once the search commenced, anyone still lurking about in any of the houses would be considered hostile. The search got underway in all its tediousness. House by house, never knowing when or where someone would

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